

A New Cognitive Hypothesis: Joy May Be Linked to Lower Total Evaluative Load (June 2026)

Within this hypothesis, joy is not a product of amplification. Efforts to amplify reward may even activate evaluative processes that precisely interfere with joy.

To explore this possibility, the exercises below are intended for rare, **seconds-long use**.

Follow my work for an academic paper, a book, and the story of the discovery. The paper is titled "A Regime Theory of Joy" and is based on the following task: M-ZRT.

The task is being released publicly before empirical data become available, allowing anyone interested to explore the ideas and to play with the dedicated exercises.

Using the exercises excessively may increase evaluation, thereby undermining the original rationale. What follows are suspension exercises, the main exercise category.

- Stop an action.
- Do something without a reason.
- Treat two opposite options as equally acceptable.
- Notice a nearby detail.

Without:

- Measuring effect or duration
- Looking for the perfect moment.

They are often more effective within a low-narrative FPS game played at low difficulty, as the ongoing activity makes it less likely that you will stop to observe the exercise.

Useless posture correction

Slightly adjust your hand, shoulder, head, or posture in a way that does not improve anything.

Micro-movement: "Nothing to compare."

Tiny interruption without comparing before versus after.

Micro-Movement: "Almost nothing."

Make a movement so small that it barely seems to deserve the name of an exercise.

For example, a tiny shift of the shoulder, jaw, or gaze, then an immediate return to the ongoing activity.

Micro-Movement: "Without a Second Attempt."

Perform a single micro-movement, then do not repeat it during the same session, even if the mind thinks, *"not enough."*

Reading without meaning

Take a book, open it to a random page, read one or a few lines, then turn to another page for no reason. You are not following anything, you are simply exposing the brain to fragments.

Mid-Action Sip of water

Take a sip of water or coffee while engaged in another activity, such as walking, playing a game. Avoid soft drinks or any drink you like too much. Coffee is probably a good choice..

Delayed Awareness Music

Start a piece of music, then refrain from any evaluation for a few seconds.

While walking, stop and Look

Stop, notice a nearby detail, then continue.

Sidewalk, Park, Details

When two sidewalks are available, avoid deciding which one is better. Upon entering a park, consider several directions equally acceptable instead of optimizing the walk. Notice an interesting detail on one side and an ordinary detail on the other, then briefly hold the idea that either could receive your attention. Note: The focus is not indifference. It is suspending the impulse to rank one ordinary option as the uniquely correct choice.

Menu Hover

You move your mouse toward one menu, then pause as if another option could also happen.

Ask an absurd Question, and don't answer it:

Example: "Why does that shadow fall that way?" Then continue without attempting to answer

Accidental Question:

Act as if a question had started by mistake and was never completed. Example: "What if..." and then nothing.

Pre-Selected Question

Do not invent a new question during the exercise. Before starting, choose one fixed, ordinary, reusable question, for example: "*What was that?*" Then keep using the same question for several days. During that period, do not replace it with a different one.

Cross a Street While Thinking About Something Else

Keep attention on a completely different thought. Switch without interrupting it. The sidewalk change remains peripheral.

Unclaimed Crossing After crossing

avoid mentally claiming authorship ("I decided to cross"). "Crossing occurred."

Random Reversal

Cross to the other side, then 10-20 seconds later cross back for no reason.

Double Reversal

Cross, cross back, cross again. No side ends up being the destination.

Tag an object as the most important in the room, without looking directly at it.

It's a salience exercise. Combined with suspension, it is thought to improve joy's odds.

More at florianmorin.com, "A Regime Theory of Joy", or at SSRN, 2026.